Akbar declared that if their cheetahs caught the antelope, it meant that victory was theirs. A cheetah was released and the antelope was caught, confirming not only Akbar's unshakeable belief in his own destiny, but his men's implacable faith in their Padshah's quasi-divine powers. The men covered a staggering 50 miles per night; there were twenty-seven chosen noblemen with Akbar, amongst them the most trusted and true men of his empire including Abdur Rahim, Bairam Khan's son, and Akbar's kokas, Saif Khan Koka and Zain Khan Koka. After a few days, Akbar switched to a horse and 'like the full moon, traversed an immense distance in the night'. In nine days, Akbar and his men reached the outskirts of Ahmedabad, having covered a distance of 800 kilometres on camels and horses with intimidating speed.

Akbar mounted a favourite white horse, Noor Baize, strapped on his moulded armour made of Damascus steel, and kept 100 men under his own command. Fifteen were Hindus and included Raja Birbal, Man Singh Darbari, Raja Bhagwant Das, Ram Das Kachhwaha, the musician Lal Kalawant, and four painters, Sanwal Das, Jagannath, Har Das, and Tara Chand. He then inspected all his noblemen and soldiers, his great amirs resplendent and fearsome in their armour. Each of the noblemen wore a cuirass of finely-tempered steel, 'including a breastplate, backplate, and two smaller pieces for the sides—all carved and engraved, decorated with tassels, and held together by leather straps. Underneath was a coat of mail with mail sleeves. Helmets were carved with visors and nose-guards and a network of mail which protected the neck.' Akbar's helmet was decorated with delicate gold damascene and had a spike at the top.[*] The horses too were similarly armoured 'front, back, head, and neck with crafted steel pieces'. At the front of the army was a man holding the imperial alam,[†] a lion and a sun against a moss green background. Then with the roll of the drummers leading the way and the trumpeters sounding their chilling wail, the Mughal army headed for the Sabarmati River.

On the opposite bank of the river, Muhammad Husain Mirza had come to enquire about the army that was heading his way.

'This is the army of the Emperor, which has come from Fatehpur to exterminate those who have been faithless to their salt,' responded Subhan Quli, a Mughal soldier.

'My spies only fourteen days ago left the Emperor at Fatehpur,' shouted back Muhammad Husain Mirza, clearly discomfited. 'And if it is the